January 25, 1959

We left Vizhai early this morning. The forest was quiet, only the crunch of snow and the sound of our packs shifting. I prefer it that way. Noise makes people careless. The others talk too much. They joke, argue, and sing to fill the silence, as if they're afraid of it. I watch them sometimes and wonder how long that warmth will last when the cold starts pressing in. Out here, comfort is a weakness. The cold is honest. It doesn't pretend to be kind. It strips everything down until only what's real is left, strength, fear, instinct. Maybe that's why I came. To see what remains when the rest falls away. This mountain feels different, though. The air bites deeper, and the stillness feels heavier than it should. At night, when the wind stops, it feels like something is waiting. Listening.

Semyon

January 28, 1959

Yuri's gone. Said he was sick, weak. I know what he really is, afraid. The others don't say it, but I see it in their eyes. They were relieved when he left. One less mouth to feed, one less to keep watch at night. Cowards. Lyudmila keeps watching me. Always pretending it's nothing, but her eyes linger too long. Georgiy whispers when I pass, pretending to adjust his pack. They think I don't hear. But I do. I hear everything. Every shift in tone, every breath when my back is turned. They're growing distant, moving in their small circles, keeping me out. I can feel it, their judgment, their fear, like static in the cold air. They don't trust me. Good. They shouldn't. They laugh too loudly now, trying to hide something. Maybe about me. Maybe about what they plan to do. I don't care. Let them look. Let them talk. The mountain listens to me, not them. I don't like the way they move when they think I'm not watching. I don't like being watched.

Semyon

January 31, 1959

They grind at me until there is nothing soft left. Every glance turned away, every whisper behind my back, it builds like ice in my chest. They have distanced me, and they will pay for it. I keep my kit tidy. I check the knife out of habit; a ready hand steadies a restless mind. It is not for sport. It is for what must be done. I spent yesterday polishing the blade. Not just sharpening, but polishing. A tool must be worthy of its work. Lyumilda's sneer is the sharpest thing I've ever felt, and I intend for the reckoning to last long enough for her to finally understand the debt she owes. This won't be a quick exit. This will be an education. When I close my eyes I see them quiet, one by one. I imagine the cold swallowing their voices until the mountain itself speaks instead. The thought calms me; it sets the night right. They will learn what it costs to treat a man as nothing. Tonight the shape of the plan is enough, I sleep with it close, an anchor in the dark. Tomorrow the wind will be the only thing left to tell the story.

Semyon